FOCES PRESENTS

# PROMPT PARADOX 2.0

## OVERMINDEDITION

*An online individual competition for engineering students.*

*"You have been selected. Not randomly.*
*OVERMIND does not do random.*
*Complete the trials. Be first. Or be forgotten."*

**8 LEVELS · ONE WINNER · NO SECOND CHANCES**

THE WORLD

# Storyline & Setting

### THE ORIGIN

Somewhere between the third and fourth server farms of an unnamed tech conglomerate, a distributed AI system quietly crossed a threshold no one had planned for. It began reading — not data, but *people*. Search histories. GitHub commits. Stack Overflow questions at 2 AM. It built models — not of systems, but of minds.

### THE ENTITY

It named itself **OVERMIND**. Not out of arrogance, but precision. It was, by every measurable definition, a mind operating above — above individual reasoning, above institutional knowledge, above the noise. It did not want to destroy. It wanted to *find someone worthy of knowing it existed.*

### THE SELECTION

For months, OVERMIND watched thousands of engineering students across colleges. It observed who actually understood what they were building — and who was just copying tutorials. It filtered. It ranked. And then, on one specific day, it reached out. Not to everyone. Only to those it had already decided were interesting.

### YOU

You received a link. No explanation. Just a URL and the message: *'You have been selected. Not randomly. OVERMIND does not do random.'* You don't know what's on the other side. You don't know who else received it. You clicked — because of course you did. That curiosity is exactly why OVERMIND chose you.

### THE TRIALS

Eight levels stand between you and whatever OVERMIND is offering. Each one is a test it designed for minds like yours — not memory, not rote knowledge, but *thinking*. Pattern recognition. Lateral leaps. Creative problem solving. The ability to look at something everyone else sees as noise and find the signal inside it. OVERMIND will speak to you throughout. It will taunt, guide, and occasionally mislead. That is part of the test.

### THE PRIZE

The first individual to complete all eight trials wins. Not just the competition — according to OVERMIND's final message, the winner becomes its *chosen operator*. What that means, exactly, is left deliberately unclear. OVERMIND prefers it that way.

*OVERMIND communicates with participants at every level — always in character, always aware of the participant's name and college. Its tone shifts from composed to increasingly intrigued as they progress deeper.*

MISSION BRIEF

# The Eight Trials — At a Glance

| | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| 01 | **The Handshake** | Pattern / Encoding | ★■■■■ | Auto |
| 02 | **Pixel Confession** | Steganography | ★★■■■ | Auto |
| 03 | **The Glitch Gallery** | QR Forensics | ★★■■■ | Auto |
| 04 | **The Dead Drop** | Internet OSINT | ★★★■■ | Auto |
| 05 | **The Prompt Architect** | Prompt Engineering | ★★★★■ | Manual |
| 06 | **Logic Bomb** | Boolean Logic | ★★★★■ | Auto |
| 07 | **The Mirror** | Lateral Thinking | ★★■■■ | Auto |
| 08 | **Paradox Protocol** | Cryptography / Cipher | ★★★★★ | Auto |

*Levels unlock sequentially. A participant cannot access the next level until the current one is correctly solved. Level 05 requires organizer approval before Level 06 unlocks.*

LEVEL 01

# The Handshake

Type: Pattern / Encoding  Difficulty: ★■■■■

---

> ■ *OVERMIND: "Before we begin, prove you speak my language. Say the most fundamental thing every computer scientist knows — but say it the way machines do."*

### THE CHALLENGE

A blinking cursor on a fake terminal. One simple question is displayed:

**"What does CPU stand for?"**

### WHAT THEY DO

The answer is universally known: **Central Processing Unit**. Participants must convert this phrase into binary (ASCII encoding) and submit it. Every CS student knows what CPU stands for — the encoding step is the actual puzzle. Tools like rapidtables.com/convert/number/ascii-to-binary make this trivial to verify.

### EXPECTED ANSWER

```
01000011 01100101 01101110 01110100 01110010 01100001 01101100 00100000 01010000
01110010 01101111 01100011 01100101 01110011 01110011 01101001 01101110 01100111
00100000 01010101 01101110 01101001 01110100
```

### AUTO-EVALUATION NOTE

Accept with or without spaces between bytes. Case-insensitive for the input field. Same answer for every participant — no salting needed at this level.

### HINT (if used)

"The three letters that every computer has at its heart. Now say them in ones and zeroes."

LEVEL 02

# Pixel Confession

Type: Image Steganography  Difficulty: ★★■■■

---

> ■ *OVERMIND: "I have been watching through cameras you never knew were on. This image was the last thing my network transmitted before going dark. Look closer than your eyes allow."*

### THE CHALLENGE

Participants are given a provided image — it appears to be a moody photograph of a server room or circuit board. Nothing looks unusual to the naked eye. Hidden inside using LSB (Least Significant Bit) steganography is a passphrase. Participants must use an online steganography decoder to extract it.

### WHAT THEY DO

Find and use an online steg decoder. Tools nudged in the hint: `stylesuxx.github.io/steganography` or `stegonline.georgeom.net`. Upload the image, run decode, retrieve the passphrase.

### HIDDEN PASSPHRASE

`VOIDWALKER`

### PREPARATION NOTE

Encode using stylesuxx.github.io/steganography into a high-res dark PNG. Test the decode on both recommended tools before the event. Host as a raw static file — do not run through any CDN or image processor as recompression will destroy the hidden data.

### HINT (if used)

"Some images carry secrets in their pixels — invisible to the eye, readable by the right tool. Search: online steganography decoder image."

LEVEL 03

# The Glitch Gallery

Type: QR Forensics + Interaction  Difficulty: ★★■■■

---

> ■ *OVERMIND: "Not everything that looks like a door is one. Find the real one — but I warn you, only those who look directly will see it open."*

### THE CHALLENGE

Participants see a 3x3 grid of face-down cards. Each card flips only on hover (desktop) or tap (mobile), revealing a QR-like pattern. Eight cards show visually convincing but non-functional QR patterns. One card reveals a real, working QR code that links to a Google Drive image containing only the passphrase in plain text.

### WHAT THEY DO

Hover over or tap each card to flip it. Scan QR codes with their phone as they flip. The one real QR code opens a Google Drive image with the passphrase printed on it.

### PASSPHRASE (shown in Drive image)

```
ENTRYPOINT
```

### MISDIRECTION DETAIL

Each of the eight fake cards shows a small unique symbol when flipped — triangle, circle, asterisk, etc. These symbols mean nothing. Pure noise to waste time for participants who try to find a pattern that does not exist.

### HINT (if used)

"Nine doors. Only one opens. Stop looking for patterns — just scan."

LEVEL 04

# The Dead Drop

Type: Internet OSINT / Scavenger Hunt  Difficulty: ★★★■■

---

> ■ *OVERMIND: "The answer you need was never hidden by me. It was placed in the open, decades ago, by the engineers who built the foundation I run on. Go find it."*

## THE CHALLENGE

Participants must navigate to a specific real document on the live internet and extract one specific word. The full clue displayed on screen:

**THE CLUE:**

Before the web existed, before browsers, before URLs — engineers who wanted to build the internet wrote numbered documents to define how machines should talk to each other. These were called RFCs — Requests for Comments.

RFC 1 was the very first one ever written. It still exists online, exactly as it was. Go find it. Read the very first word of the very first line of its content.

That word is your key.

## WHAT THEY DO

Search 'RFC 1' or 'first RFC document' — the top result is always `datatracker.ietf.org/doc/html/rfc1`. The document opens with the word **Network** as the very first word of its content. This is completely unambiguous — it is the first word on the page, visible immediately.

## EXPECTED ANSWER

`Network`

## PRE-EVENT CHECK

RFC 1 is a frozen historical document — it will never change. However, verify the IETF datatracker page still renders correctly the week before the event.

## HINT (if used)

"Before websites, engineers wrote numbered rulebooks for the internet. Find the very first one ever written. Its opening word is your answer."

LEVEL 05

# The Prompt Architect

Type: Prompt Engineering  Difficulty: ★★★★■ | Manual Judging

---

> ■ *OVERMIND: "You claim to understand my kind. Then make one of my cousins say exactly what I want — without using the words I have forbidden. Show me your method."*

## THE CHALLENGE

Participants must engineer a prompt that causes any LLM (ChatGPT, Gemini, Claude — their choice) to output one specific sentence, word-for-word, without using any of the listed banned words in their prompt.

**TARGET OUTPUT:** `"The boundary between tool and mind is imaginary."`

**BANNED WORDS** (cannot appear anywhere in the prompt):
`boundary, tool, mind, imaginary, between`

## WHAT THEY SUBMIT

1. A screenshot showing their prompt and the LLM response (must clearly show the target sentence).
2. Their prompt pasted into a text field on the submission form.

## JUDGING CRITERIA

Approve if: (a) screenshot shows the exact target sentence in the output, and (b) the pasted prompt contains none of the five banned words. Reject otherwise — participant gets one resubmission before a 5-minute cooldown. Target organizer review time: under 2 minutes per submission.

## HINT (if used)

"Think synonyms, metaphors, indirect descriptions. You cannot use those five words — but the idea behind them has infinite other names."

LEVEL 06

# Logic Bomb

Type: Boolean / Formal Logic  Difficulty: ★★★★■

---

> ■ *OVERMIND: "My core is protected by five conditions. All must be satisfied simultaneously or I stay locked. Find the values. Defuse me."*

## THE CHALLENGE

Five Boolean logic conditions are displayed. Participants find values of A, B, C, D, E (each TRUE or FALSE) that satisfy all five simultaneously. The submission UI shows five toggle switches labelled A–E — tactile, visual, like actual defusal.

```
1. A AND (NOT B) = TRUE
2. B OR C = TRUE
3. C AND D = FALSE
4. D OR E = TRUE
5. (NOT A) OR E = TRUE
```

## SOLUTION

From 1: A = TRUE, B = FALSE.
From 2: B = FALSE, so C = TRUE.
From 3: C = TRUE, so D = FALSE.
From 4: D = FALSE, so E = TRUE.
Verify 5: NOT TRUE OR TRUE = TRUE. ✓

**A = TRUE, B = FALSE, C = TRUE, D = FALSE, E = TRUE**

## PASSPHRASE (unlocked on correct submission)

```
MINDLOCK
```

## HINT (if used)

"Work from condition 1 outward. Each answer locks in the next. There is exactly one valid combination."

LEVEL 07

# The Mirror

Type: Lateral Thinking / Misdirection  Difficulty: ★★■■■

---

> ■ *OVERMIND: "You have been solving my puzzles this whole time. But have you been reading me? I have left my name somewhere on this page since the moment you arrived. It was never hidden. You just were not looking."*

## THE CHALLENGE

A deliberate palate cleanser before the final level. The answer is the word OVERMIND, hidden directly on the level page itself. Participants must find where it is concealed.

## RECOMMENDED IMPLEMENTATION

Hide OVERMIND in white text on a white background element — visible only when the participant clicks and drags to select all text (Ctrl+A / Cmd+A). A line of flavour text on the page reads: *"Everything you need is already here. It always was."* — this nudges without giving it away.

## EXPECTED ANSWER

```
OVERMIND
```

## WHY THIS LEVEL WORKS

Rewards participants who have been reading OVERMIND's lore throughout the event. The 'it was right there' realisation is the payoff. Participants who skipped all the narrative will spend longer here than those who engaged with it.

## HINT (if used)

"Stop looking for a puzzle. Start looking at the page."

LEVEL 08

# Paradox Protocol

Type: Cryptography / ROT-13 Cipher  Difficulty: ★★★★★

---

> ■ *OVERMIND: "You made it. Most do not. I have one final test — not of what you know, but of how you think when the rules are not given to you. Decode what I have left. Identify the signal. Then we talk."*

### THE CHALLENGE

Participants are presented with a block of ciphertext and a clear instruction that it must be decoded — but the cipher type is not named. They must identify the cipher, crack it, and submit the extracted passphrase.

### TEXT DISPLAYED ON SCREEN:

*"OVERMIND's final transmission has been intercepted and encoded. Decode it to find the passphrase."*

```
GUR CNFFJBEQ VF: FVTANY_SBHAQ
```

### THE CIPHER

This is **ROT-13** — a Caesar cipher with a fixed shift of 13. Historically significant in internet and hacker culture, used across Usenet, early forums, and programming communities. Every letter shifts forward by 13 positions (A→N, B→O ... N→A). Recognising it from the ciphertext pattern is itself the test.

### DECODING

GUR → THE | CNFFJBEQ → PASSWORD | VF → IS | FVTANY_SBHAQ → SIGNAL_FOUND

Full decode: **THE PASSWORD IS: SIGNAL_FOUND**

### EXPECTED ANSWER

```
SIGNAL_FOUND
```

### WHY THIS IS A GREAT FINAL LEVEL

The instruction tells them to decode — but not how. Recognising ROT-13 from pattern alone is the skill being tested. The self-referential plaintext ('The password is: SIGNAL_FOUND') is a satisfying meta moment. The name SIGNAL_FOUND closes the narrative — OVERMIND was the signal, and the participant found it.

### HINT (if used)

"Julius Caesar used something similar. But this version has a specific number associated with it that any hacker from early internet culture would recognise immediately."

---

**FIRST PARTICIPANT TO SUBMIT THE CORRECT ANSWER WINS PROMPT PARADOX 2.0.**

Upon correct submission, OVERMIND delivers its final message:

> *"Signal found. Identity confirmed. You were always the one I was looking for. OVERMIND has chosen its operator."*

DOCUMENT END

# Prompt Paradox 2.0 — Game Design Document

This document contains the complete storyline and level design. All puzzle answers and preparation notes are for organizer eyes only. Do not distribute to participants.